



FOOD FOR THOUGHT

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Empowering female athletes through nutrition

Being mindful of **protein intake** is paramount in achieving peak performance, evident in how our women cricketers tailor their diets to meet their unique needs.

Women athletes require superior nutrition than men to excel in their performances. This need becomes even more pronounced by the hormonal fluctuations experienced throughout the monthly cycle. With the Women's Premier League underway, the importance of proper nutrition for female athletes cannot be overstated. Consistent performance in any sport demands a steadfast commitment to eating right — a lesson underscored by my work with esteemed athletes like Mithali Raj, Jhulan Goswami, Harmanpreet Kaur, Smriti Mandhana, and Renuka Thakur.

Understanding the unique dietary and supplement requirements of female athletes reveals the decisive impact that nutrition has on their performance, far more than their male counterparts. While men might sustain subpar eating habits for some time, female athletes find their performance deteriorating within just a couple of weeks of poor nutrition.

When selecting a protein supplement for women, it is important to consider a few key factors. First and foremost, it is crucial to choose a high-quality protein supplement that is specifically formulated for women's nutritional

needs. Look for those with protein sources like whey and casein, or plant-based ones like pea or rice protein. **Ensure that the supplement is free from harmful additives or unnecessary ingredients.**

In terms of dosage, the recommended protein intake for women varies depending on factors such as age, weight, activity level, and fitness goals. As a general guideline, women who engage in regular exercise may benefit from consuming 0.8 to 1.2 grams of protein per kilogram of body weight per day. Divide this total protein intake evenly throughout the day, including protein from whole food sources as well as protein supplements.

The best time to consume a protein supplement is typically post-workout, as this is when the body is most receptive to protein for muscle repair and recovery. Consuming a protein shake or supplement within 30 minutes to an hour after exercise can help promote muscle protein synthesis and accelerate recovery.

However, protein supplements can also be consumed as a snack or meal replacement throughout the day to help meet daily protein requirements and support overall health and fitness goals.

Here is a ranking of dietary protein options based on their PDCAAS

(Protein Digestibility-Corrected Amino Acid Score), with 1 being the highest score and 10 being the lowest. Call this the IPL scoring card of proteins:

1. Whey protein isolate
2. Whey protein concentrate
3. Casein protein
4. Soy protein isolate
5. Egg white protein
6. Pea protein
7. Rice protein
8. Hemp protein
9. Sacha inchi protein
10. Quinoa protein

Women cricketers may face various nutrition and health issues due to the physical demands of the sport. These may include inadequate calorie intake leading to energy deficiency, low intake of essential nutrients such as iron and calcium, which can impact performance and bone health, and challenges in maintaining proper hydration levels during training and matches.

Additionally, menstrual irregularities and disorderly eating patterns are common among female athletes and can have long-term repercussions on overall health.

Proper nutrition education, individualised meal planning, and access to sports nutrition professionals are crucial in addressing these concerns and optimising the health and performance of women